# DBQ Sourcing 5A: Historical Situation

Oct 28, 2026 · @CJ DeRuyter

## What historical situation means

Historical situation is the specific event or development happening when a document was made that explains why it exists and why it says what it does. It is the most frequently credited HIPP element in the College Board samples, and the easiest for students because it uses content knowledge they already have.

**How it feeds Purpose:** the situation creates the need. Kennedy's 1962 push for elderly health insurance only makes sense in a moment when liberal ideas about using federal power were rising. Students who name the situation can almost always follow with "so the author wanted to…" (see 5D).

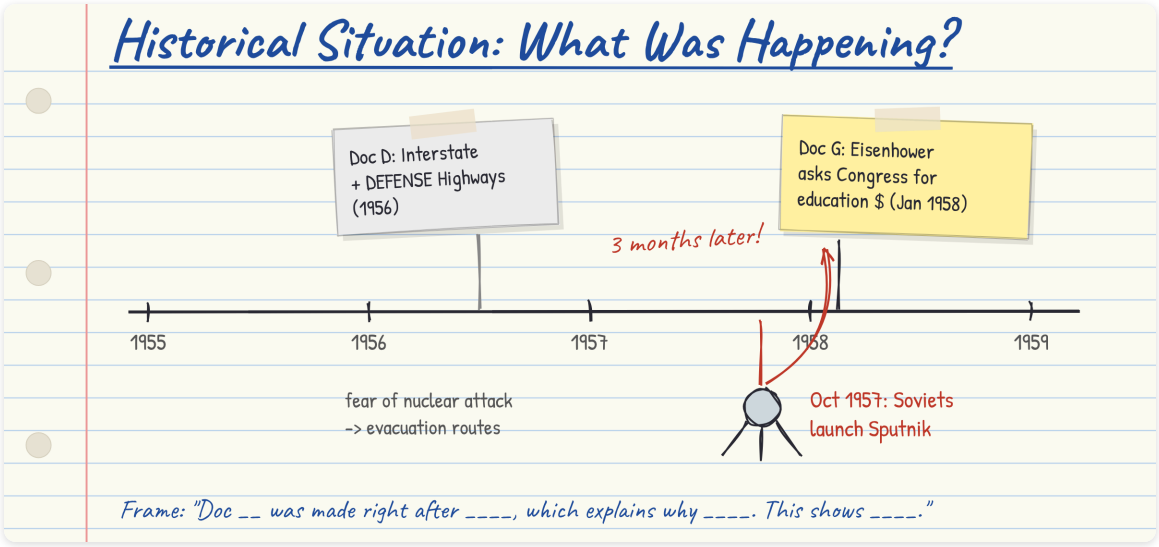
To earn credit, a historical-situation explanation must:

1. **Name a specific event or development**, not just the era ("the Cold War" alone is too broad).
2. **Link it to the document**: why that moment produced this source.
3. **Connect it to the argument**: what the link proves about the prompt.

**Watch the overlap:** historical situation is *not* the document's content (2024 Set 2 Sample 1C lost evidence credit for Doc 7 by discussing only its situation), and the same fact can't earn both outside evidence and sourcing.

## The formula

> "Document [X] was created [during / shortly after] [specific event], when [what was going on]. This explains why [author] [says / shows] [content], which supports my argument that [claim]."




1. **Read the source line first.** Circle the date.

2. **Ask: what happened in the 1–5 years before this date** that relates to the topic? Write the event in the margin.
3. **Name it specifically:** "the Soviet launch of Sputnik in October 1957," not "the space race."
4. **Say why that moment produced this document.** Use "because," "in response to," or "this explains why."
5. **Finish with the argument.** "This shows…" tied to the thesis.

**Cold War DBQ cheat sheet** (situations worth naming; written for this guide):

| Doc | Date | Situation to name |
|---|---|---|
| A, Eisenhower press conference | March 1954 | McCarthy's anticommunist investigations at their peak, weeks before the Army-McCarthy hearings |
| B, Dulles on Guatemala | June 1954 | CIA-backed overthrow of Guatemala's elected government, same month |
| D, Interstate Highway Act | 1956 | Fear of nuclear attack; need to evacuate cities and move troops |
| E, Kennedy inaugural | January 1961 | Arms race and the "missile gap" debate of the 1960 election |
| G, Eisenhower on education | January 1958 | Sputnik, three months earlier |

Docs C and F are images; check their content before naming a situation.

## Examples that earned credit

| Source | Document | What was credited |
|---|---|---|
| 2024 Set 2, Sample 1A (score 7) | Doc 1 | Tied to the Treaty of Versailles, Woodrow Wilson, and earlier imperialism in the Spanish-American War to explain the isolationist argument. |
| 2024 Set 2, Sample 1A | Doc 2 | Placed in the Bolshevik Revolution and the Red Scare that followed. |
| 2023 Set 2, Sample 1A (score 7) | Doc 3 | Placed in the passage of the Chinese Exclusion Act of 1882. |
| 2023 Set 2, Sample 1A | Doc 4 | Tied to the Spanish-American War and newly acquired territory. |
| 2025 Set 1, Sample 1A (score 7) | Doc 4 | Kennedy's speech as an example of the Keynesian idea of “priming the pump.” |
| 2025 Set 1, Sample 1A | Doc 7 | Growing influence of the New Right in the Republican Party, leading to Reagan's 1980 election. |
| 2025 Set 1, Sample 1B (score 5) | Doc 3 | The military rationale for highway construction, tied to increased government economic intervention. |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 2025 Set 2, Sample 1A (score 7) | Doc 7 | Placed within Theodore Roosevelt's Square Deal, connected to an argument about positive social change. |

**College Board model sentence** (2025 Set 1):

> "Document 3 illustrates how competition with the Soviet Union during the Cold War influenced the federal government's decision to spend money on federal projects, such as the interstate highway system."

**Cold War model** (written for this guide):

> "Eisenhower's call for federal education money in Document G came just three months after the Soviet Union launched Sputnik, which made Americans fear they were falling behind in science and missiles. This explains why he framed school funding as 'national security,' and it shows the government tried to answer Cold War fear by building long-term strength rather than only reassuring the public."

## Examples that did not earn credit

| Source | Attempt | Why it fails |
|---|---|---|
| 2025 guidelines (non-example) | "Document 3 was photographed during the Cold War." | Identifies the era; explains nothing about why it matters. |
| 2025 Set 2, Sample 1C (score 2) | Situation for Docs 1 and 6 | "Too vague." No specific event named. |
| 2024 Set 2, Sample 1C (score 3) | Doc 7 discussed *only* through its situation | Counted toward sourcing, but cost the document as evidence. Students need content *and* sourcing. |

**Cold War non-examples** (written for this guide):

- "Document A was written in 1954, during the Cold War." Era only.
- "Document D was written when Americans were buying more cars." True, but it misses the defense situation the document's title points to, and it isn't tied to the prompt.
- "Document G was written after Sputnik." Specific, but stops before explaining why that matters to the argument. Add "This explains why…" and "This shows…"

## Expert tips

- **Definition:** place the document in its larger historical context, e.g. Lincoln's second inaugural during the Civil War. A good lead-in: "The events in this document are situated in the larger context of…, and that's important because…"
- **A reader's recommendation:** APUSH teachers who score at the AP Reading say historical situation is the most reliable sourcing route, because point of view, audience, and purpose attempts often "fall flat." The best way to earn it is to bring in an outside piece of evidence that situates the document.

**Rubric note:** the College Board samples back this up (historical situation is the most-credited element), but one fact can't earn both sourcing and outside evidence. The 2024 Set 2 Sample 1C commentary says its Lend-Lease sentence "could also count for historical situation provided it was not counted as evidence beyond the documents." Students who situate a document with outside evidence should plant a *second*, separate outside example.

## Grader checklist

1. Is a specific event or development named (not just a decade or "the Cold War")?
2. Is it accurate, and did it come before or at the time of the document?
3. Does the essay say why that moment produced this document?
4. Is it tied to an argument about the prompt?

Four yeses = this document counts toward the two needed for the sourcing point.

**Feedback stem:** "You placed Document [X] in [era]. Name the specific event (for example, [event]) and explain how it caused the author to write this, then tie it to your thesis."